PHARMACOVIGILANCE INTERNSHIP

ASSIGNMENT 04: SEVERITY & CASE CLASSIFICATION

Submitted by: Anisha Hussain

Date: 09-11-2026

1. INTRODUCTION

Case classification is an important process in data organisation and analysis. It involves categorising individual cases or study participants according to specific attributes such as age, gender, occupation, role, geographical location and other relevant characteristics.

Classification helps researchers organise collected information systematically and compare different groups based on the characteristics assigned to them. In healthcare and pharmacovigilance, systematic case organisation is particularly useful for identifying patterns, reviewing patient information and supporting meaningful analysis.

A case classification sheet provides a structured framework for assigning attributes and their corresponding values to individual cases.

2. OBJECTIVES OF CASE CLASSIFICATION

The major objectives of case classification include:

- To organise individual cases systematically.
- To identify and group cases based on common characteristics.
- To facilitate comparison between different subgroups.
- To improve the accuracy and consistency of data analysis.
- To simplify the retrieval and interpretation of information.
- To support systematic documentation and reporting.

3. UNDERSTANDING CASE CLASSIFICATION

Case classification refers to assigning predefined attributes to individual cases or participants.

For example, in a research study involving 100 participants, the researcher may classify individuals based on:

- Gender: Male or Female.
- Age group: 18–25 years, 26–40 years, or above 40 years.
- Role: Student, Employee or Researcher.
- Location: Urban or Rural.

Once these attributes are assigned, researchers can compare different subgroups and identify similarities or differences in their responses.

For example, researchers may compare the opinions of male participants aged 40 years with those of female participants aged 25 years regarding environmental changes.

4. COMPONENTS OF A CASE CLASSIFICATION SHEET

A case classification sheet generally consists of the following components:

4.1 Classification Table: A classification table is created to store and organise the attributes associated with individual cases. It provides a central structure for categorising participants.

4.2 Attributes: Attributes are the characteristics used to classify cases.

Examples include:

- Gender
- Age group
- Occupation
- Role
- Location

4.3 Attribute Values: Attribute values represent the possible categories available under a particular attribute.

For example:

ATTRIBUTE	POSSIBLE VALUES
Gender	Male, Female
Age group	18–25, 26–40, Above 40
Location	Urban, Rural
Role	Student, Employee, Researcher

4.4 Default Values

The tutorial demonstrates two predefined values:

- Unassigned: Indicates that no value has yet been assigned to a particular attribute.
- Not Applicable: Indicates that a particular attribute does not apply to the selected case.

These values help maintain clarity and prevent inappropriate classification.

5. PROCEDURE FOR CREATING A CASE CLASSIFICATION SHEET

The tutorial demonstrates the creation of a classification sheet using qualitative data analysis software.

The procedure involves the following steps:

Step 1: Open the Project

Open the existing project or create a new blank project in the software.

Step 2: Navigate to Case Classification

Locate the navigation panel and expand the relevant folder:

Data-Coded Cases → Cases → Case Classifications.

Step 3: Create a New Classification

Select the Case Classifications folder. Right-click in the working area and choose the option for creating a new classification.

Step 4: Name the Classification Sheet

Enter an appropriate name for the new classification table.

For example: Participant Demographics Sheet.

Click OK to create the classification table.

Step 5: Create New Attributes

Right-click inside the newly created classification table and select the New Attributes option.

Enter the name of the attribute, such as Gender.

Step 6: Add Attribute Values

Open the Values tab and add the required values.

For the Gender attribute, the values may include:

- Male
- Female

The software also provides default options such as Unassigned and Not Applicable.

Step 7: Repeat the Process

Follow the same procedure to create additional attributes, such as age group, role and location.

Step 8: Transfer Existing Attributes

The tutorial also demonstrates how previously created attributes can be transferred between classification tables.

The user can select the required attributes, right-click and choose Cut. After navigating to the new classification table, the Paste option can be used to transfer them.

Step 9: Review the Classification Sheet

Finally, verify that all required attributes and their corresponding values are available in the newly created classification table.

6. IMPORTANCE OF CASE CLASSIFICATION IN HEALTHCARE

Case classification has several applications in healthcare data management.

1. **Patient categorisation:** Patients can be grouped according to demographic characteristics, age groups and other relevant information.
2. **Clinical research:** Researchers can compare outcomes between different patient subgroups.
3. **Pharmacovigilance:** Adverse drug reaction reports can be organised using relevant patient and case characteristics, such as age, gender, suspected drug and reaction type.
4. **Data analysis:** Classification makes it easier to identify trends and patterns within collected information.
5. **Documentation:** A structured classification system improves consistency and organisation during data management.

It is important to note that demographic case classification is different from the regulatory assessment of adverse drug reactions. ADR seriousness, severity and expectedness require separate clinical and pharmacovigilance criteria.

7. Practical Example

Consider a hypothetical healthcare research study involving five participants.

CASE ID	GENDER	AGE GROUP	ROLE	LOCATION
C001	Male	18–25	Student	Urban
C002	Female	26–40	Employee	Rural
C003	Male	Above 40	Employee	Urban
C004	Female	18–25	Student	Urban
C005	Male	26–40	Researcher	Rural

Using the classification sheet, the researcher can group participants according to gender, age group, occupation and geographical location.

For example, the researcher can compare the responses of male and female participants or examine differences between urban and rural participants.

This demonstrates how classification helps convert unorganised information into structured and meaningful data.

8. ADVANTAGES OF CASE CLASSIFICATION

- Provides systematic organisation of data.
- Simplifies comparison between different groups.
- Improves data retrieval and interpretation.
- Reduces confusion during data analysis.
- Supports consistent documentation.
- Helps identify patterns and relationships between different attributes.

9. CONCLUSION

Case classification is an essential technique for organising and analysing research data. By creating classification tables, defining attributes and assigning appropriate values, individual cases can be systematically grouped according to their characteristics.

The tutorial demonstrates the practical process of creating a participant demographics sheet, adding attributes, defining attribute values and transferring existing attributes between classification tables.

In healthcare and pharmacovigilance, structured case classification can support efficient data organisation and analysis. However, demographic classification should not be confused with the clinical assessment of ADR severity, regulatory seriousness or expectedness.

10. REFERENCES

1. Tutorial video provided as part of the internship learning material: Creation of Case Classification Sheets.
2. International Council for Harmonisation (ICH). E2A: Clinical Safety Data Management: Definitions and Standards for Expedited Reporting.
3. World Health Organization. The Importance of Pharmacovigilance: Safety Monitoring of Medicinal Products. WHO; 2002.